

Everything SATS — Reading Mock 3

Reading booklet

This is an original practice paper written for Everything SATS. It follows the layout and question types of the real Key Stage 2 English reading test, but it is **not** a real past paper.

There are three texts in this booklet:

1. Dancing on Our Patch
2. Two Wheels: The Story of the Bicycle
3. The Weaver of Harrowdale

Print this booklet and the question booklet. Read one text, answer its questions, then move on to the next text.

Free to print, copy and share. No accounts, no paywall. everything-sats.github.io

Dancing on Our Patch

This is a story about a girl called Ocean at her first dance competition.

Ocean had been dancing since she was five, but she had never danced in front of strangers. Her shows at the village hall didn't count. Everyone in the audience there was somebody's gran or somebody's little brother, and they clapped whatever happened, even the year Harry's costume fell off.

Today was different. Today there would be judges.

The competition was held in a huge sports hall. When Ocean pushed open the double doors, the noise hit her like a wave: music thumping from three speakers at once, mums calling out names, and the squeak of a hundred pairs of shoes on the polished floor. Girls in glittering costumes stretched against the walls. One of them was doing the splits while eating a banana.

'She's done this before,' Ocean whispered.

'Everyone's done this before,' said Edie gloomily. 'Except us.'

Edie was Ocean's best friend, and they were dancing a duet together. They had practised it in Edie's garden every evening for six weeks, until the lawn had a bare patch in the shape of their routine. Edie's dad said he was going to put a little fence around it and sell tickets.

They found a spot in the corner and changed into their costumes: matching blue dresses with a silver ribbon at the waist.

Then Ocean looked at the list pinned to the wall, and her stomach dropped. They were dancing seventeenth, straight after a girl called Priya Shah, who had won the whole competition last year.

'We can't go after her,' said Ocean. Her voice came out thin and wobbly. 'Everyone will compare us. Edie, I think we should go home.'

Edie stared at her. 'Go home? After six weeks?'

'We could say I've got a headache.' It was not completely a lie. Ocean's head was beginning to throb, and her hands felt cold and damp.

For a moment Edie said nothing. Then she took Ocean's hands and squeezed them. 'Remember the bare patch on the lawn?' she said. 'That's us. We made that. So when we go out there, we're not dancing against Priya Shah. We're just dancing on our patch.'

Ocean wanted to argue, but she couldn't think of anything to say.

The next hour crawled by. One boy forgot his steps halfway through, stood still for a terrible second, and then carried on as if nothing had happened; the audience cheered louder for him than for anyone. Ocean clapped so hard that her palms stung.

Then Priya Shah danced. She moved as if the music were lifting her up and putting her down wherever it pleased. When she finished, the hall was silent for a heartbeat before the applause crashed in.

'Number seventeen,' called a voice. 'Ocean and Edie.'

Ocean's legs walked her to the middle of the floor without asking her permission. The lights were brighter than she had expected, and she could not see the judges' faces, only three dark shapes behind a table. She glanced at Edie. Edie winked.

The music began.

For the first few bars, Ocean's arms felt stiff, like the arms of a puppet. Then she remembered the garden: the smell of cut grass, Edie's dad pretending to sell tickets, the evening they had laughed so much they fell over in a heap. Her shoulders loosened. By the time they reached the spin in the middle, she had forgotten about the judges altogether.

They did not dance perfectly. Edie was half a beat late on the final jump, and Ocean's ribbon came untied and trailed behind her like a silver tail. But when the music stopped and they held their last pose, they were both grinning so widely that their cheeks ached.

They did not win. Priya Shah won, and everybody agreed she deserved it. Ocean and Edie came fifth, and each won a certificate with a gold star on it.

On the way out, Ocean noticed a small girl sitting on a bench by the door, her face pale, clutching a pair of dance shoes. A number was pinned to her dress for the afternoon competition.

Ocean sat down beside her. 'Is it your first time?' she asked.

The girl nodded without looking up.

'Mine too,' said Ocean. 'Can I tell you a secret?' She took the loose silver ribbon out of her pocket and tied it gently around the girl's wrist. 'You don't have to dance against anyone. You just have to find your patch.'

Two Wheels: The Story of the Bicycle

This is an information text about how the bicycle was invented and improved.

Today, bicycles are so ordinary that it is easy to forget they had to be invented at all. Yet just over two hundred years ago, nobody had ever ridden one. The bicycle grew slowly, as each inventor tried to fix the problems of the machine before.

A machine with no pedals

In 1817, a German inventor called Karl Drais showed off a curious new machine in Mannheim. It had two wooden wheels, one behind the other, joined by a wooden frame. There was a seat for the rider and a handlebar for steering, but there were no pedals at all. Instead, the rider sat on the frame and pushed against the ground with their feet.

Drais called his invention a 'running machine', and it also became known as a draisine, after its inventor. On a smooth, dry path, a rider could travel much faster than a person on foot.

For a short time, running machines became fashionable in several countries. In Britain, they were nicknamed 'dandy horses' or 'hobby horses'. However, they were heavy, and most roads were rough, muddy and full of ruts. The craze soon faded.

Pedals at last

In the 1860s, inventors in France had a new idea: they fixed pedals to the front wheel. For the first time, a rider could keep both feet off the ground and still move forward. These machines were often called velocipedes, from Latin words meaning 'fast foot'.

Riding a velocipede was not a comfortable experience. The wheels were made of wood with iron rims, and the streets of many towns were paved with bumpy cobblestones. Every stone sent a jolt through the rider's body. It is no surprise that in Britain these machines earned the nickname 'boneshakers'.

Why were penny-farthings so tall?

On these early machines, one turn of the pedals made the front wheel go round exactly once. This meant that the bigger the front wheel was, the further the machine

travelled with each push of the pedals. So, during the 1870s, makers built front wheels that were larger and larger, while the back wheel shrank.

The result was the penny-farthing. Its name came from two British coins of the time: the large penny and the much smaller farthing. Placed side by side, they looked rather like the machine's two wheels. At the time, however, most people simply called it an 'ordinary' bicycle.

Penny-farthings were fast, but they were also dangerous. The rider perched high above the ground, almost on top of the huge front wheel. If that wheel hit a stone or a pothole, the machine could stop suddenly, flinging the rider forwards over the handlebars and head-first onto the road. Getting on and off was tricky too. These machines were mostly ridden by young men who were daring enough to take the risk.

The safety bicycle

During the 1880s, inventors found a cleverer answer. Instead of making one wheel enormous, they gave the bicycle two wheels of roughly the same size and placed the rider between them. The pedals turned a chain, which turned the back wheel. Toothed wheels on the chain meant that even a small back wheel could travel a long way with each turn of the pedals.

One of the most famous of these machines was the Rover, made in Coventry by John Kemp Starley in 1885. Riders sat much lower down and could put their feet on the ground when they stopped, so they were far less likely to fall. For this reason, machines like the Rover were called 'safety bicycles'.

A softer ride

The early safety bicycles had tyres of solid rubber, which gave a hard and bumpy ride. Around 1888, a Scottish vet called John Boyd Dunlop, who lived in Belfast, set out to make his young son's tricycle more comfortable. He fitted the wheels with tubes of rubber and filled them with air.

Air-filled tyres are called pneumatic tyres, from a Greek word meaning 'air' or 'breath'. They soaked up the bumps in the road, and cyclists soon discovered that they made bicycles faster as well as more comfortable.

How did bicycles change people's lives?

By the 1890s, the bicycle had become hugely popular in Britain and many other countries. A bicycle cost far less than a horse, and it did not need feeding, grooming or a stable. For the first time, many ordinary working people could afford to travel further than they could walk.

This brought a new kind of freedom. People could live further from their work, visit friends and family in other villages, or ride out into the countryside at weekends.

For many women, the bicycle was especially important. It allowed them to travel on their own, whenever they chose. Long, heavy skirts were not practical for cycling, so some women began to wear shorter skirts or loose, baggy trousers called bloomers. This helped to change ideas about what women could wear and do.

Still rolling

More than two hundred years after Karl Drais first showed off his running machine, the bicycle is still one of the most useful inventions ever made. It needs no fuel, it keeps its rider healthy, and it can carry a person almost anywhere.

The Weaver of Harrowdale

This is a traditional-style tale about a young weaver and a greedy lord.

Long ago, when the river Wend still ran silver through the valley of Harrowdale, there lived a lord whose greed was a well without a bottom. Lord Mortlake owned the castle, the mill and the bridge, and still he was not satisfied. Every morning he counted his gold, and every evening he counted it again, in case it had grown lonely and wandered off.

The people of Harrowdale were weavers. Their looms clattered from dawn to dusk, and the cloth they made was famous in every market: soft as a lamb's ear, strong as a ship's rope, and coloured with dyes that seemed to hold the sunlight in them.

Lord Mortlake looked at that cloth and saw only coins. One grey spring, he nailed a proclamation to the door of the mill. From that day, it announced, every household must give a third of all it wove to the castle.

The valley groaned. A third of their cloth meant a third less bread on every table. Yet no one dared to complain, for the lord's temper was as sharp as a winter wind, and his soldiers were never far away.

Then, to everyone's surprise, a second proclamation appeared beside the first. Lord Mortlake, it seemed, fancied himself a judge of fine things. Any weaver who could bring him a cloth in which he could find no fault might name any reward she wished. But any weaver who failed would lose her loom.

'It is a trap,' muttered the old weavers in the square. 'He will find fault with the finest cloth under heaven, and keep it besides.'

They were right. The first to try was Martha Greaves. Lord Mortlake held her blanket up, frowned, and declared that one thread was a hair's breadth thicker than the rest. The next weaver's cloth was 'too blue'. The one after that was 'not blue enough'. By midsummer, seven looms stood silent in the castle cellars, and seven families had no way to earn their bread.

Among the weavers of Harrowdale was a girl named Wren, who was twelve years old and small for her age, with quick fingers and quicker eyes. And she had noticed something. Lord Mortlake loved his gold, but there was one thing he loved even

more: himself. In his great hall hung eleven portraits of Lord Mortlake, and not a single painting of anything else.

So Wren went home and sat down at her mother's loom. For forty nights she wove by candlelight while the rest of the valley slept. Her shuttle darted to and fro like a swallow skimming a pond, and slowly, thread by thread, a picture rose out of the cloth.

Then Wren rolled up her cloth and climbed the castle hill.

The great hall was crowded with courtiers. Lord Mortlake lounged on his throne, drumming his fingers on its golden arms.

'Well, child?' he drawled. 'Show me this marvel, so that I may find what is wrong with it.'

Wren unrolled the cloth across the floor, and a gasp rippled around the hall. There, woven in threads of every colour, was Lord Mortlake himself. Every curl of his beard was there, every jewel on his fingers. It was so lifelike that one courtier took off his hat and bowed to it before he realised his mistake.

Lord Mortlake leaned forward. He opened his mouth to announce a fault, and then he closed it again.

'The nose,' he said at last. 'The nose is too long.'

Wren bowed politely. 'Forgive me, my lord,' she said, 'but I wove only what I saw. If there is a fault in the nose, then the fault is not in my cloth.'

At the back of the hall, somebody tried very hard not to laugh, and failed. The sound spread from courtier to courtier until the whole court was shaking. Lord Mortlake's face turned the colour of a ripe plum.

He could not say that the picture was poor, because the picture was him. He could not say that his own face was flawed, because he had spent his whole life believing that it was perfect. The lord was caught in a net of his own making.

'There is ... no fault,' he said, through gritted teeth.

'Then I may name my reward,' said Wren, and the hall fell silent. Everyone expected her to ask for gold, or jewels, or a fine house of her own.

'I ask that the seven looms be returned to their owners,' said Wren, 'and that no weaver in Harrowdale shall ever again give a third of her cloth to the castle.'

Lord Mortlake had given his word in front of the whole court, and a lord who breaks his word in public is a lord nobody will ever trust again. That very afternoon, seven looms rattled down the castle hill, and the proclamation on the mill door was torn down and used to light the baker's oven.

As for the cloth, Lord Mortlake hung it in the great hall beside his eleven portraits. It is said that he stood before it every morning for the rest of his life, staring at the nose and wondering.

And in Harrowdale, when a child grows boastful or greedy, the old weavers still shake their heads and say, 'Mind your nose, now. You never know who might be weaving it.'